

Gretser LA-EN

Defensio Controversiarum Bellarmini — Felix II and Liberius: recognition legitimates a pope (*Excerpta*)

by Jakob Gretser, S.J. (1562–1625); *Defensio of Bellarmine's Controversies*,
Ingolstadt 1607–1609 (= *Opera omnia*, tomi VIII–IX)

[Online Location of Text Here](#)

- *Pivotal passages, verified against the page images in the owner's bellarmine-defenses corpus (July 2026): Tom. II, cols. 531–532 (the agnitus-et-palam-habitus text, print-verified) and cols. 1045–1052 (the Felix II mechanism, agent-verified against the rendered pages).*
- *Last Edit: July 15, 2026.*
- *Version: 1.0*
- *Selection: the Felix II / Liberius cluster, with the external-forum principle*

Note on this selection: recognition-legitimation applied to a pope, defended against the Protestant controversialist Sutcliffe. Felix II entered by an election Gretser concedes was vitiosus — an imperial intrusion while Liberius lived. Gretser's resolution: when Liberius fell (communicating with the Arians), Felix "was acknowledged and openly held as legitimate Pontiff" — and from that time "Felix was MADE legitimate Pope... and remained true Pontiff to the end of his life." The mechanism is the external forum: the Church judges by what is public — "for men are not bound to, nor can they, search hearts, but judge what is external" — the papal twin of Bellarmine's De Conciliis II.9 rule ("whatever may lie hidden in their hearts") and a seventeenth-century anticipation of this repository's §X argument on the intention of the elect: no interior state, of elector or elect, can defeat the public constitution of the title. Gretser thus witnesses the cause-version of the fact-guarantee (recognition makes the pope) two decades before Castro Palao's sanatio and a century before Pallavicino's second-election theory. Classification: School 1 (cause; note unassigned). The datum that even schismatic emperors venerated their antipopes "as Vicars of Christ" — conceding the office itself while mistaking its occupant — completes the picture: the acceptance-criterion was so native to the Christian mind that even its abusers presupposed it.

The Felix II / Liberius cluster

<i>Latin</i>	<i>English</i>
[Contra Sutcliffium, de Felice II:] Licet Felicis ingressus fuerit vitiosus; postea tamen, quando Liberius cum Arianis communicare coepit, pro legitimo Pontifice agnitus et palam habitus est.	[Against Sutcliffe, on Felix II:] Although the entry of Felix was faulty; afterwards, however, when Liberius began to communicate with the Arians, he was acknowledged and openly held as legitimate Pontiff.
[De eodem, fusius:] Ait Bellarminus, Felicem non fuisse legitimum Pontificem usque ad lapsum Liberij. [...] Et ex illo tempore Felix legitimus Papa factus est [...] mansitque Felix verus Pontifex usque ad finem vitae suae.	[On the same, at greater length:] Bellarmine says that Felix was not legitimate Pontiff until the fall of Liberius. [...] And from that time Felix was made legitimate Pope [...] and Felix remained true Pontiff to the end of his life.
[De mechanismo — forum externum:] [Depositio possibilis tantum] propter externam haereseos speciem [...] non enim homines tenentur, aut possunt corda scrutari, sed quae externa [iudicant].	[On the mechanism — the external forum:] [Deposition is possible only] on account of the external appearance of heresy [...] for men are not bound to, nor can they, search hearts, but judge what is external.
[Datum adiacens:] Etiam schismatici imperatores antipapas suos tanquam Vicarios Christi venerabantur.	[Adjacent datum:] Even schismatic emperors venerated their antipopes as Vicars of Christ.